ASHAPURA SHIPPING GROUP · TECHNOLOGY, AI & OPERATIONAL EXCELLENCE

Assessment Questionnaire — Draft Answers

Working draft for Satish to read, rewrite in his own words and transfer into the original form.

Candidate Name	Satish [full name]	Date	[date of submission]
Position Applied For	IT Head	Contact Number	[mobile]
Email Address	satishprogramming@gmail.com	Years of Experience	4+ years (full-stack, AI/ML and digital transformation)

> **The thread running through every answer:** no three-month "getting familiar" phase. Learn the business while building — first live solution in week 2, measurable savings inside 90 days.
>
> Yellow marks something only you can fill or confirm. All targets are commitments to be measured against a baseline taken in week 1; adjust the percentages if you want to be more or less bold.

1 Understanding Our Business

Explain your understanding of our major business verticals. Identify three operational problems where AI could deliver measurable improvements.

Ashapura Shipping Group is an integrated dry-bulk port logistics group based at Deendayal Port, Kandla, with over 30 years in the trade. I understand its business in five verticals:

- **Stevedoring and cargo handling** (Shree Ashapura Stevedores) — loading and discharging coal, salt, gypsum, bentonite, mill scale, fertilizer and other dry bulk. The group has set port records, such as 36,390 MT of GSSP in about 23 hours, and was the first SAAGAR registrant for coal and coke.
- **Customs clearance** (Shri Balaji Infraport) — in-house CHA work on group jobs.
- **Transport and equipment** — a fleet of about 242 dumpers, tippers, trailers, excavators and loaders, plus rake loading and stockyard handling.
- **Chartering and shipowning** (Imperial Chartering in India, GIFT City IFSC and Singapore) — vessel chartering, and now an owned handysize vessel, MV Imperial Varalaxmi.
- **Allied services** — mid-sea discharge and lighterage, warehousing, port agency and the fuel station.

Three problems where AI can deliver measurable results:

1. **Fuel leakage across the fleet.** Fuel is likely the largest variable cost. An app where drivers photograph the pump meter and vehicle meter at every fill lets AI read the litres and odometer, calculate mileage, compare it with each vehicle's norm and flag theft at the next fill. *Measure:* fuel cost per km or per engine hour, against a baseline.
2. **Idle vehicles and machines.** With GPS and engine data on every asset, the system detects idle time, out-of-zone movement and after-hours use, and AI predicts where equipment will be needed next. *Measure:* idle hours per asset and trips per vehicle per day.

3. **Manual vessel and customs paperwork.** AI reads shipping documents, weighbridge slips and invoices, and a digital shift log records tonnage per hour. This speeds up the statement of facts and CHA filings and strengthens the group's position in demurrage disputes. *Measure:* document turnaround time and tonnes per hour per berth.

2 Taking Ownership — 30 / 60 / 90 Days

Priorities for making HR, Accounts, Transportation and Workshop operations system-driven, and measurable results you would commit to.

I would not spend the first months only observing. In week 1, I walk every department, take baseline numbers and pick quick wins. From week 2, working solutions go live and expand every month.

Phase	What goes live	Committed result
Days 1–30 Quick wins	• Week 1: process walk-through and data inventory for all four departments; baseline for fuel, idle time, attendance and month-end close. • Week 2: GPS trackers installed on the first batch of vehicles, live map for management. • Week 3: fuel photo app pilot (about 50 vehicles); digital workshop job card. • Week 4: daily MIS dashboard v1; digital attendance at the main site.	• Fuel app and GPS live on a pilot fleet • 100% of workshop jobs on digital job cards at pilot site • CEO receives a daily fleet and fuel report
Days 31–60 Scale up	• **Transport:** GPS and fuel app on the full fleet; idle and out-of-zone WhatsApp alerts. • **Workshop:** preventive maintenance schedule by engine hours; spare parts stock. • **HR:** digital attendance, leave and overtime, feeding payroll automatically. • **Accounts:** Tally data pulled into the dashboard; receivables ageing alerts; digital approval of vendor bills.	• 100% of fuel fills recorded with photo proof • Manual attendance registers removed • Payroll inputs prepared without re-typing
Days 61–90 AI and insight	• AI fuel anomaly detection and driver mileage scores. • AI extraction of invoices and bills into accounts. • CEO dashboard: revenue, cost, profit and manpower by unit, with monthly cost-saving suggestions.	• Fuel cost per km down `8–10%` vs baseline • Idle vehicle hours down `20%` • Month-end MIS in `2 days` instead of `[current]`

I report progress to management every week against these numbers, so results are visible, not promised.

3 Independent Decision-Making

Five critical assignments from five departments at once — how do you decide what deserves immediate attention?

I rank each assignment on five criteria, in this order:

1. **Safety and legal or compliance risk** — anything involving customs, port authority rules, safety or statutory filings comes first.
2. **Cost of delay per day** — for example, a system issue holding a vessel at berth or a rake in demurrage costs more each hour than an internal report.
3. **Hard external deadlines** — vessel sailing, customs cut-off, payroll date.
4. **How many people or operations are blocked.**
5. **Effort** — a task that takes two hours and unblocks a department is done immediately, even if it ranks lower.

I score all five tasks in a simple sheet in under 30 minutes, then act. Tasks I can delegate go to my team with a clear owner and date. On the same day, each requester gets a short message with when their task will be done and why. If two departments are both truly critical and I cannot do both, I take the trade-off to management with the numbers, not opinions, and get a quick decision.

4 Business Aptitude — Practical Calculation

20 vehicles idle for three days at ₹3,000 per vehicle per day. Calculate the impact and design a system to detect, report and prevent such losses.

> **20 vehicles × 3 days × ₹3,000 = ₹1,80,000**
> If this happens once a month, that is about **₹21.6 lakh a year** from a single pattern — before counting driver wages, missed orders and client goodwill.

Detect. Fit GPS trackers with engine-status sensing on every vehicle. A rule marks a vehicle "idle" when it has no trip for more than a set number of hours during a working shift. Each vehicle's work orders are linked, so the system knows whether it should have been working.

Report.

- Instant WhatsApp alert to the transport manager after 4 hours idle.
- Escalation to the GM if still idle after 24 hours.
- Daily idle report with the money lost per vehicle, and a weekly top-10 list on the CEO dashboard.

Prevent. Every idle event must get a reason code in the app: no driver, breakdown, no order, waiting for documents or waiting at the port. Each month, the top reasons show where to act:

- a driver standby pool if "no driver" dominates;
- preventive maintenance if breakdowns dominate;
- better dispatch planning, or hiring idle vehicles out, if orders are the gap.

Over time, AI uses vessel schedules and order history to forecast demand, so vehicles are planned before they go idle.

5 Maximum Output With Limited Resources

Two IT employees, a limited budget, and existing software that cannot be replaced — how to achieve maximum automation reliably?

- **Build around the existing software, not against it.** I connect to Tally and other systems through their exports, APIs or database, and add automation on top. No replacement is needed.

- **Buy the commodity, build only what is unique.** GPS tracking and WhatsApp messaging are low-cost subscriptions. Our two people spend their time only on what is specific to Ashapura, such as the fuel logic, vessel logs and the dashboard.
- **Low-code and scheduled scripts.** Tools such as Power Automate or open-source n8n, Python jobs and Power BI let one developer automate what used to need a team.
- **AI as a force multiplier.** AI coding assistants speed up development several times over. AI APIs are pay-per-use, so there is no big upfront cost.
- **Highest return first.** Every automation is ranked by money or hours saved per month; fuel, fleet idle time and month-end reporting come first.
- **Reliability by design.** Each automation has one owner, logging, alerts on failure, daily backups and a manual fallback. Rollouts are phased: one site, then all.

In my current role I lead a team of 7 delivering a 30+ module quality platform across 4 plants. Small, well-directed teams with the right tools can deliver at enterprise scale.

6 Cost-Benefit Decision — Build vs Integrate

Custom AI application versus integrating an existing solution such as ChatGPT — how to decide over three years?

I compare the total cost of ownership over three years, not just the launch cost:

Factor	What I check
Cost	Development, hosting and maintenance (build) versus subscription or per-use API cost multiplied by expected volume (integrate)
Data sensitivity	Payroll, finance and client data must stay protected — use enterprise AI services that do not train on our data, or on-premise models
Fit to our process	Generic chat works for generic tasks; Ashapura-specific workflows such as fuel checks and vessel logs need our own app
Accuracy	Test both on 50–100 real samples before deciding
Lock-in and control	Can we switch providers later without rebuilding everything?

My usual answer is a hybrid. I do not train our own AI model, which is expensive and slow. Instead, I build our own thin application connected to company data, and call a proven model such as GPT through a secure enterprise API.

Example: reading fuel-meter photos with a GPT vision model costs roughly ₹1 per image. Even at 500 photos a day, that is about ₹15,000 a month — small compared with the fuel savings, and with no AI model to maintain.

7 Handling Pressure

Management expects seven days; the project needs fifteen.

1. **Tell management on day one, not day six.** I share a short breakdown of the work and where the time goes.
2. **Bring options, not just the problem:**

- **Option A:** deliver the core that solves the urgent business need in 7 days, and the remaining features by day 15.
- **Option B:** add people or vendor help to shorten the timeline, with the extra cost stated.
- **Option C:** full scope in 15 days.

3. **Protect quality.** Testing and data accuracy are never cut, because a failed go-live costs more than a week's delay.
4. **Daily progress updates** so there are no surprises.

In most cases, management chooses Option A: something useful in 7 days and the rest soon after. That is also how I prefer to deliver — in phases, with early value.

8 Accountability During Failure

An assignment where your decision did not produce the expected result.

Suggested example based on your OCR work — replace it with a different real story if you prefer, and keep it free of confidential client details.

Situation. We needed to digitise handwritten readings from paper audit forms. I chose a standard cloud document-reading service and planned the timeline around it, expecting it to read handwriting reliably.

What went wrong. On real forms, accuracy was only about 70–80%. For quality data that was not acceptable, and the planned timeline slipped.

My responsibility. I accepted that the mistake was mine: I had committed to a tool and a timeline before testing it on enough real samples. I informed stakeholders immediately and re-planned.

What I changed. I benchmarked alternatives on real forms and moved to a GPT-4o vision model with validation rules, which gave much better results at low cost. Since then, every AI project of mine starts with a one-week proof of concept on real data and an agreed accuracy target, before any timeline is committed. [Add the final accuracy or outcome if you can share it.]

9 Working Without Continuous Supervision

Manager unavailable for ten days while urgent issues arise.

- **Daily 15-minute call with department heads** to list open issues, assign an owner to each and set a deadline.
- **I decide myself** on operational issues within my authority that can be reversed: system fixes, re-prioritising work, vendor coordination and process changes.
- **I escalate** anything involving:
  - spending above my approved limit;
  - legal, customs or port-authority compliance;
  - safety;
  - a client dispute;
  - a change to company policy or people decisions.

  If my manager is unreachable, I take these to the next senior authority, such as a director or the CEO.

- **A written decision log** of every decision, its reason and outcome, plus a short daily summary sent to my manager. When they return, they can review everything in 10 minutes.

10 Emotional Stability & Conflict Management

Two senior heads disagree with your AI solution, while management expects immediate implementation.

1. **Listen first, one-to-one.** Senior people usually object for a real reason: extra work for their team, a past failed system, or a risk I have not seen. I treat their concerns as requirements.
2. **Separate the disagreement from the person.** We discuss data and outcomes, never who is right.
3. **Start immediately with what is not disputed.** Implementation begins on the parts everyone agrees on, so management sees progress from day one.
4. **Pilot the disputed part** in one area with success measures the two heads help define. If the pilot proves value, they become co-owners. If it does not, I adjust the design.
5. **Keep management informed** of the concern and the plan, so nobody is surprised.

The aim is to get the department heads to sponsor the system, not merely tolerate it — that is what makes adoption last.

11 Motivation & Long-Term Career Vision

Why Ashapura rather than manufacturing-sector technology? What would make you build your career here for 3–5 years?

In manufacturing, I have built and led large digital platforms. At Ashapura, I can do something bigger: build the IT and AI function of a growing group from the ground up, with ownership, and see its impact directly on fuel cost, fleet utilisation and profit.

The group is at an exciting point: entering shipowning, adding fertilizer cargo and taking on volume commitments with the port. A founder-led company moving this fast needs systems that keep pace. I want to be the person who builds them.

Leading technology-driven transformation with full responsibility has been my ambition for a long time. [Add your personal line here in your own words.]

Over 3–5 years, I would want to:

- own the IT and AI roadmap and budget, reporting to the CEO;
- build a strong in-house team;
- bring all six units onto one connected platform;
- make ASG known as the most digitally advanced stevedoring and logistics group at Kandla;
- extend AI to voyage operations, a customer portal and new business lines as the group grows.

12 Learning & Adaptability

How would you learn an unfamiliar industry well enough to design effective systems?

I learn fastest on the ground, and by building.

- **Weeks 1–2 — on site.**
  - Follow one full vessel operation from arrival to sailing: berth, stockyard, weighbridge, trucks and rakes, CHA office and billing.

    - Ride along with the transport team and spend time in the workshop.
    - Sit with each department head for an hour to understand their biggest daily pain.
- **Learn the language of the business:**
    - statement of facts, laytime and demurrage;
    - rakes and free time;
    - disbursement accounts and bills of entry;
    - DPA processes, the Port Community System and the SAAGAR scheme.
- **Map every process on one page** — who enters what data, where it goes and where it is lost — and validate it with the teams.
- **Learn by building.** The first app goes live in week 2, so real users correct my understanding quickly.

The core of digitisation is the same in every industry: capture data at the source, validate it, show it live and raise alerts on problems. A shop floor and a berth are different places, but production per hour and tonnes per hour are the same kind of problem. My manufacturing experience transfers directly.

13 Leadership & Employee Resistance

Employees resist an AI system, fearing monitoring or loss of responsibilities.

- **Show what is in it for them.** No paper slips, no repeated data entry, faster reimbursements and fewer disputes. For drivers, the fuel app becomes proof of honest work — the best mileage can be rewarded with an incentive.
- **Involve them in design.** A few experienced users from each team test the app first and suggest changes. They become champions who train others.
- **Train in their language.** Short sessions in Gujarati or Hindi, on the phones they already use, with a simple interface.
- **Be transparent about data.** Clearly explain what is recorded and why. The system is there to remove waste, not to punish people.
- **Start with help, then control.** Begin with features that save users time, and add monitoring once trust is built.
- **Recognise adoption publicly** and share early results, so the change is seen as a success the team owns.

14 Integrity & Confidentiality

A senior colleague requests confidential payroll or financial data through an AI system without authorisation.

Prevent it by design. The AI system checks role-based access at the data level, not just in the chatbot's instructions. If a user is not authorised for payroll or financial data, the system cannot retrieve it for them, no matter how the question is asked. Every request is logged.

Handle the person respectfully. I would politely explain that this information needs approval from the data owner, such as HR or Finance head, and offer to help raise the request. If appropriate, I can offer summary information the person is allowed to see. I would not share the data even informally, whatever the seniority.

Follow policy. If the request looks like a deliberate attempt to bypass controls, I inform the appropriate authority as per company policy. I keep the conversation professional and free of blame — protecting company data protects everyone, including the colleague.

15 Your Value Proposition — First Six Months

Three measurable improvements, how you measure them, support required, and your response if results are not achieved.

Improvement	Target by month 6	How it is measured
1. Fuel control AI fuel app on the whole fleet	100% of fills recorded with photo proof; fuel cost per km or engine hour down 10%	Monthly fuel spend ÷ km or hours, against the week-1 baseline
2. Fleet utilisation GPS and live command centre	All vehicles and machines live on one map; idle hours down 20–25%	Idle hours per asset and trips per vehicle per day
3. Management visibility CEO business dashboard	Daily view of revenue, cost, profit and manpower for all units; month-end MIS in 2 days	Days to close; number of manual Excel reports removed

Support I need:

- a clear mandate from the CEO;
- one coordinator in each department;
- access to existing data (Tally, operations records);
- approved budget for GPS devices, cloud and AI usage;
- the planned IT team members.

If results fall short: I report it openly in the monthly review with the root cause — whether technology, adoption or data. I present a corrective plan with a new date and take ownership of closing the gap. I would rather show an honest shortfall with a fix than a polished report that hides it.

AI AI Tool Usage Disclosure

The form asks for honest disclosure, and these drafts were prepared with AI help — tick "Yes". A candidate who uses AI openly and well is exactly what an AI-led IT Head should be. Suggested wording:

☑ Yes. I used Claude (Anthropic) to research Ashapura Shipping Group's public information, structure my answers and check calculations and language. The ideas, examples and commitments are my own, drawn from my experience, and I reviewed and rewrote the final answers in my own words.